THEPLAN · INDEPENDENT UI EXPLORATION · ROUND 1 · 2026-10-10

Two dark directions for Trish’s planner

Built from the six screenshots and the brief only. Both directions use the same tasks, events, dates and viewport sizes (1440 × 900; calendar and task detail re-flowed at 1366 × 768). Screens are shown at true pixel size — zoom the canvas to inspect.

Illustrative: every placement, proposal, Time Map band, count and date except the screenshot events (Coursera learning time, AH @ Wagner calls, Das Bros reminder, Hair — Holly Mount) and course/task titles. Invented rows are tagged “illus.”.

Not shown as fact: no real conflicts, no successful applies. The preview is unapplied; it is not evidence of what the scheduler would do.

Jump: 1a Ledger · 1b Studio · Recommendation · List + form + spec · Questions

First assessment — five most consequential opportunities

“Seen” = visible in the supplied screenshots. “Verify” = needs hands-on interaction I could not do.

1 The left rail spends its space on labels

SEEN
About 25 permanent label rows fill the rail in 01–03; epics, projects and Settings only appear far down in 04. Saved views show “No saved views yet” at prime height.

VERIFY
Whether label rows filter or navigate; whether the rail scrolls independently.

RESPONSE
Labels become filter chips on every view. Scope (Work, Inbox, epic, project, saved view) is promoted instead.

2 The calendar can’t tell kinds of time apart

SEEN
In 01, Coursera learning time is a grey slab on all seven days; Wagner calls and the Hair event overlap it unreadably. Nothing separates pinned, movable and proposed, and no Time Map bands are visible.

VERIFY
Whether bands render behind events at other zoom levels; what a preview looks like on the grid.

RESPONSE
Busy = hatch; pinned = ◆ solid; movable = ↔; proposed = + dashed; Time Map as solid / diagonal / crosshatch bands. Overlaps share lanes.

3 Task cards hide the context that matters

SEEN
Board cards in 02 truncate the course (“Kubernetes Essentials – Deploying and Managin...”) and spend a row on “Move to...” per card. 03 shows two unlabelled checkboxes per row. Dates appear as one bare “Oct 13”.

VERIFY
What each checkbox does; whether “Move to...” is the only way to change state.

RESPONSE
Titles and parent paths wrap. Dates say Due / Soft / Hard with distinct glyphs. Selection and completion are separate, labelled controls. State moves by drag.

4 Task detail is long and narrow

SEEN
In 04 the panel squeezes the board; Save appears twice; three empty mm/dd/yyyy fields sit above scheduling info; “No scheduling evaluation recorded” (honest) is below the fold.

VERIFY
Scroll position on open; what Cancel does with unsaved edits; whether Soft target ever copies from Plan.

RESPONSE
Workflow, completion and scheduling shown as three separate facts; dates carry their meaning; placement and “Why this schedule?” sit directly under dates.

5 Dense forms front-load optional work

SEEN
Import (05) stacks two tab levels and five optional fields before Propose preview. Save view (06) wraps long project names in two cramped columns; “Name” touches its field; inbox-vs-project exclusivity is a footnote.

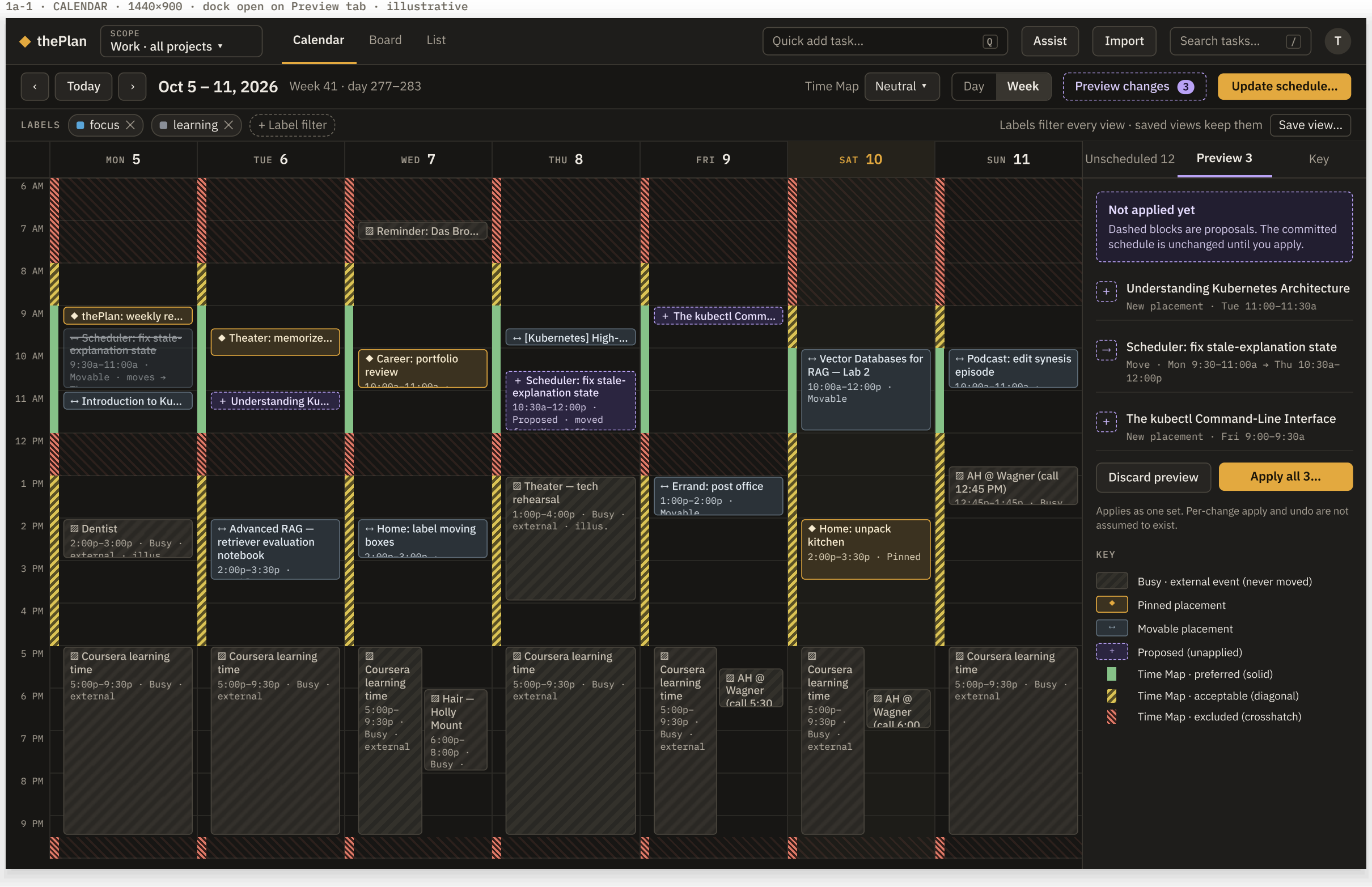
VERIFY
Whether Quick fields and Raw JSON stay in sync; how the saved-view scope validates.

RESPONSE
Grouped scope list with search and an explicit Projects | Inbox switch; tri-state labels; live match count (sketch).

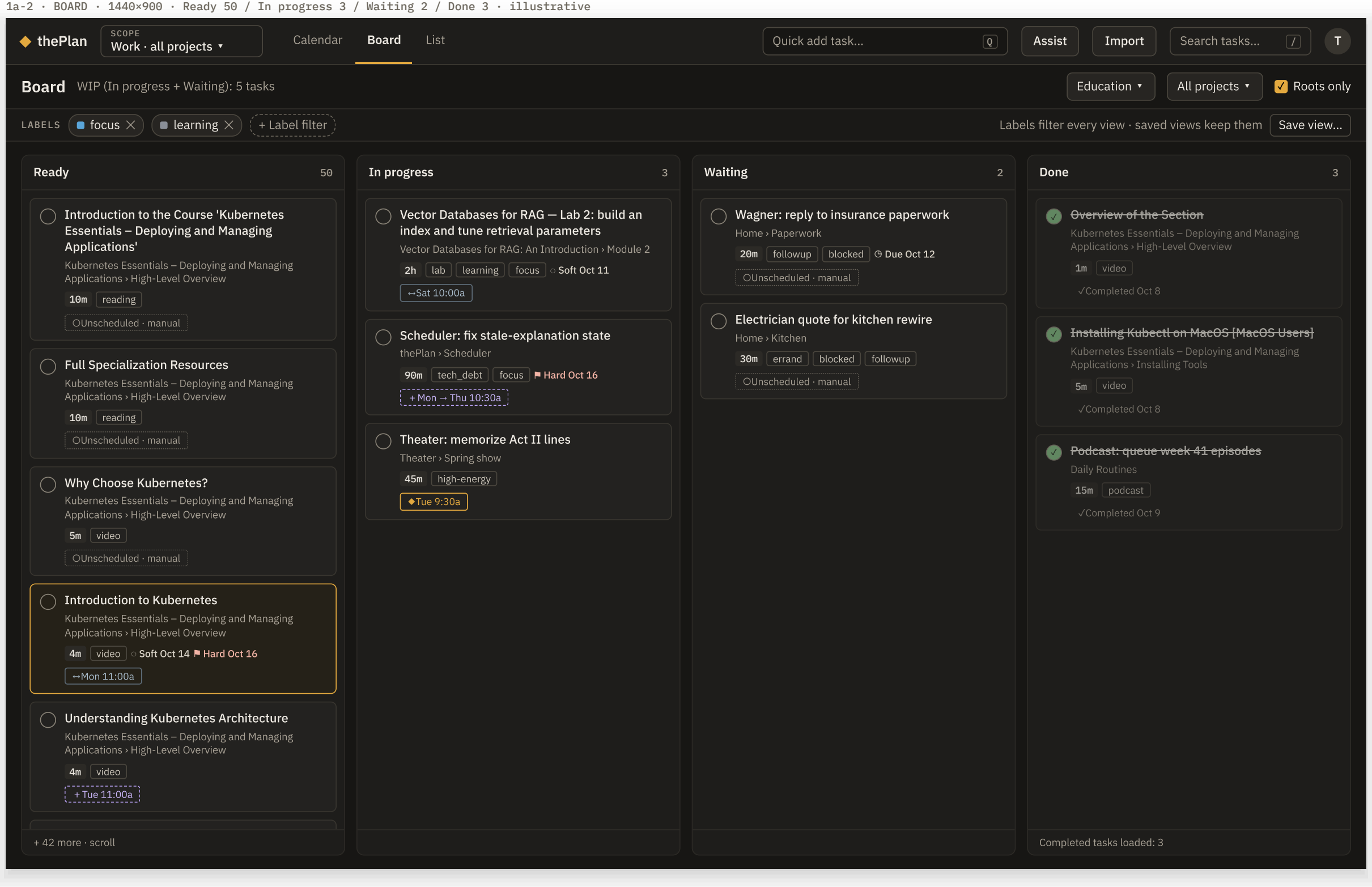
1a Ledger

Dense, warm-graphite, top-bar navigation. The calendar gets the full width; support lives in a collapsible dock.

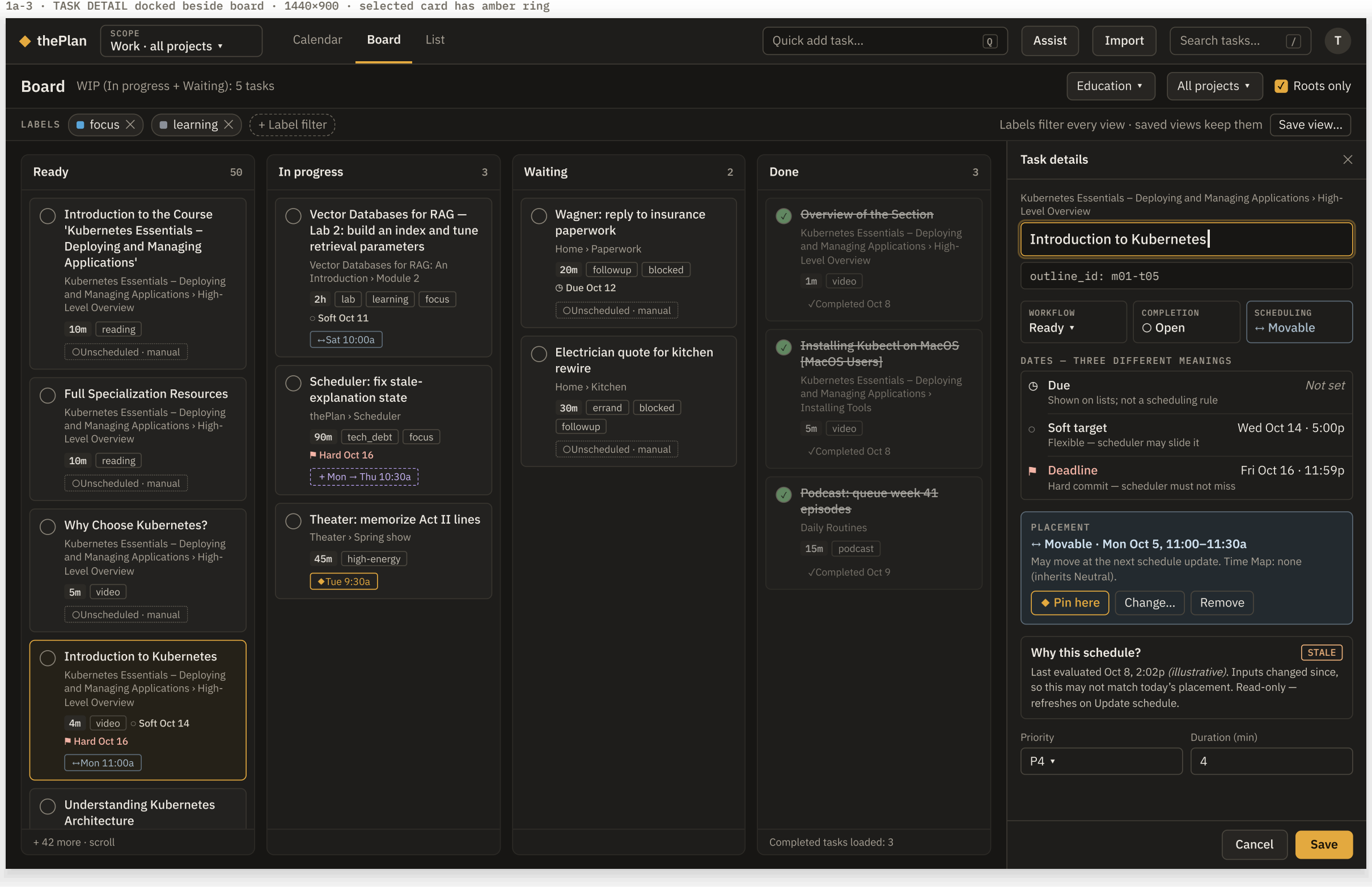
1a-1 · CALENDAR · 1440×900 · dock open on Preview tab · illustrative



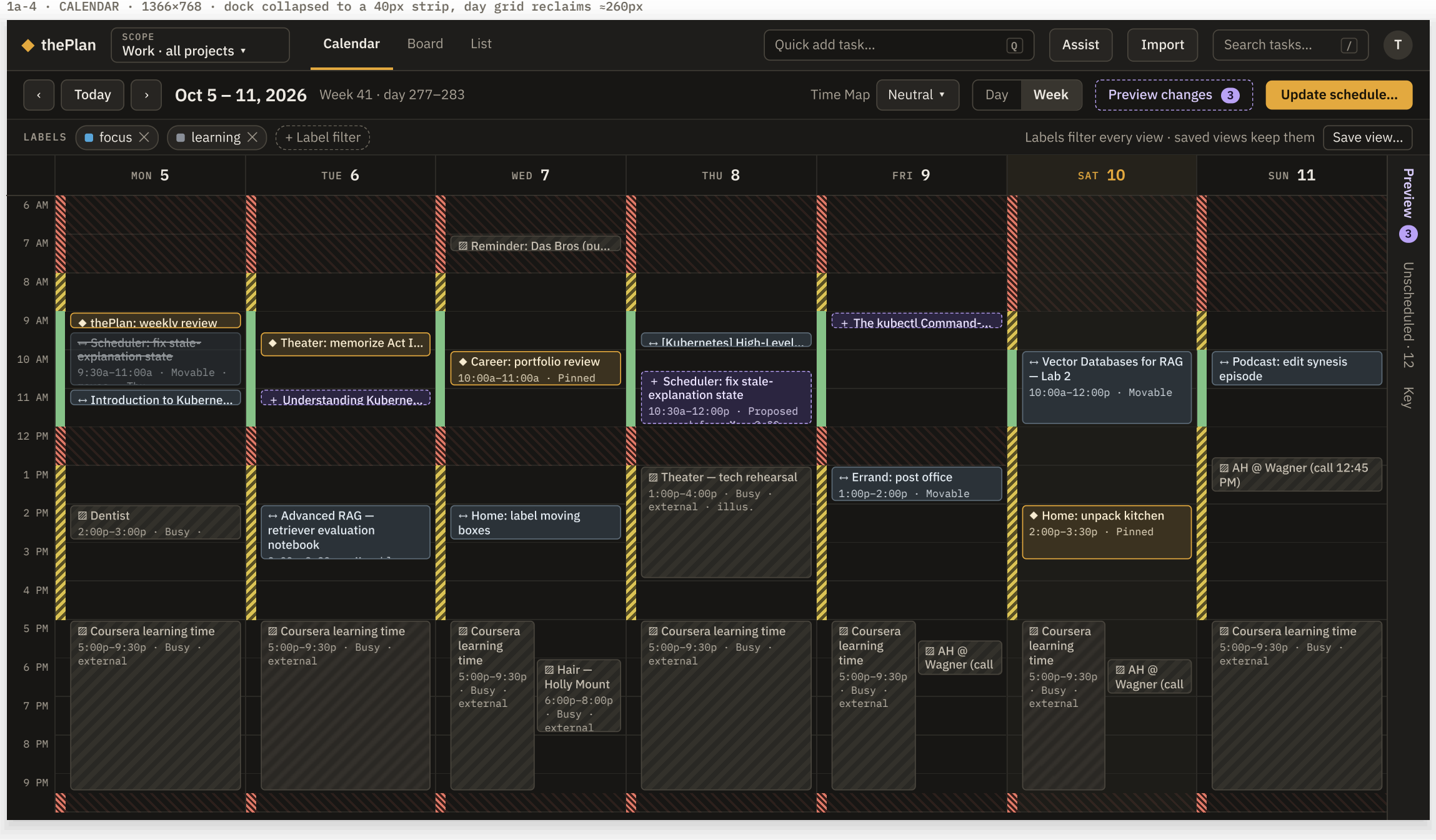
1a-2 · BOARD · 1440×900 · Ready 50 / In progress 3 / Waiting 2 / Done 3 · illustrative



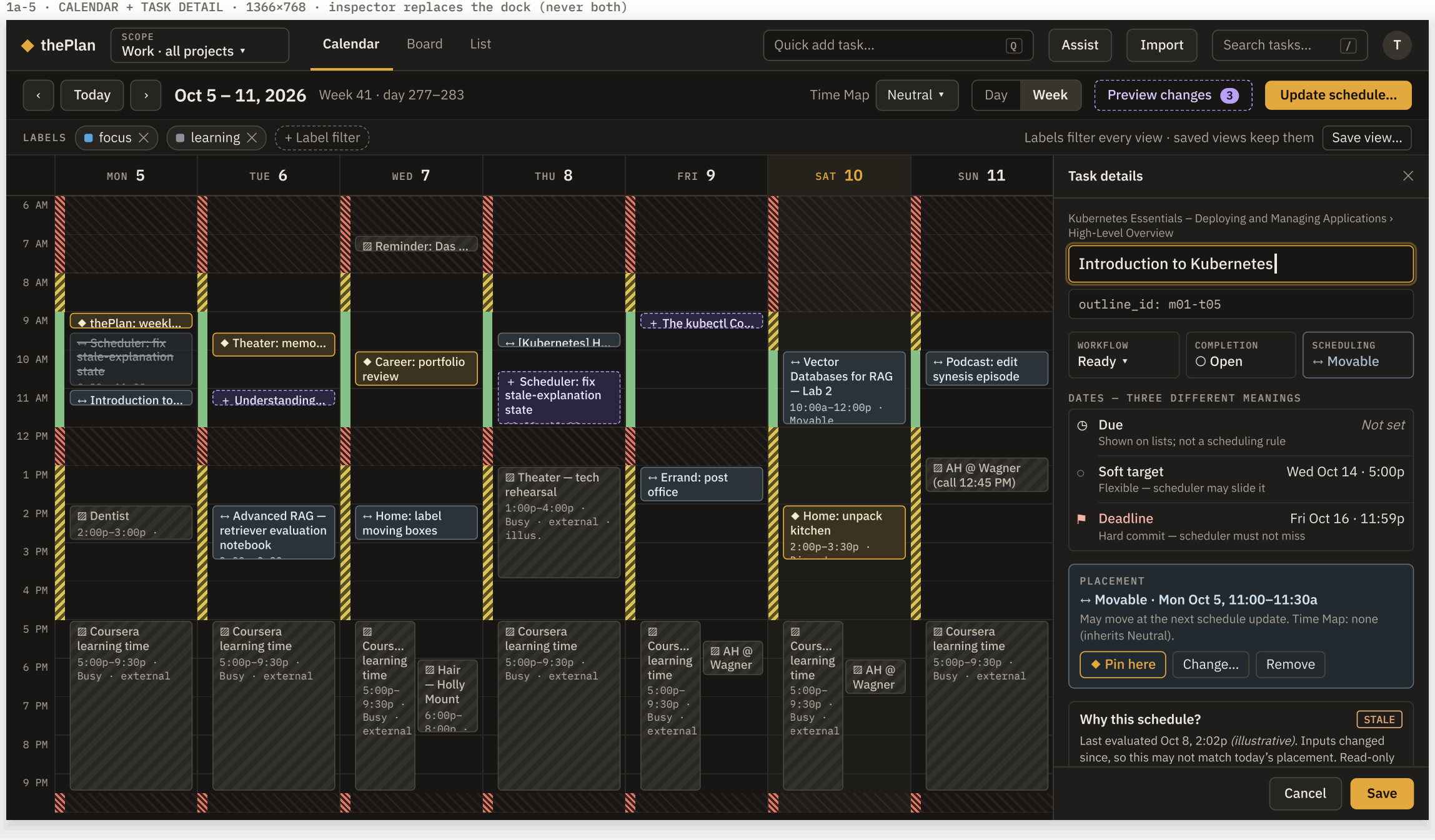
1a-3 · TASK DETAIL docked beside board · 1440×900 · selected card has amber ring



1a-4 · CALENDAR · 1366×768 · dock collapsed to a 40px strip, day grid reclaims ≈260px



1a-5 · CALENDAR + TASK DETAIL · 1366×768 · inspector replaces the dock (never both)



Strongest benefits

- Full-width calendar; dock collapses to a strip, giving back ≈260px at 1366.
- Dense, scannable cards; long titles and paths wrap in full.
- Scheduling meaning carried by shape, pattern and words, not hue alone.
- Almost no new product capability needed.

Compromises

- Epics/projects/saved views are behind a scope switcher, not always visible.
- Small mono metadata (10–10.5px) needs raising for long sessions.
- Dock tabs hide Unscheduled until opened.
- Less visual warmth than Studio.

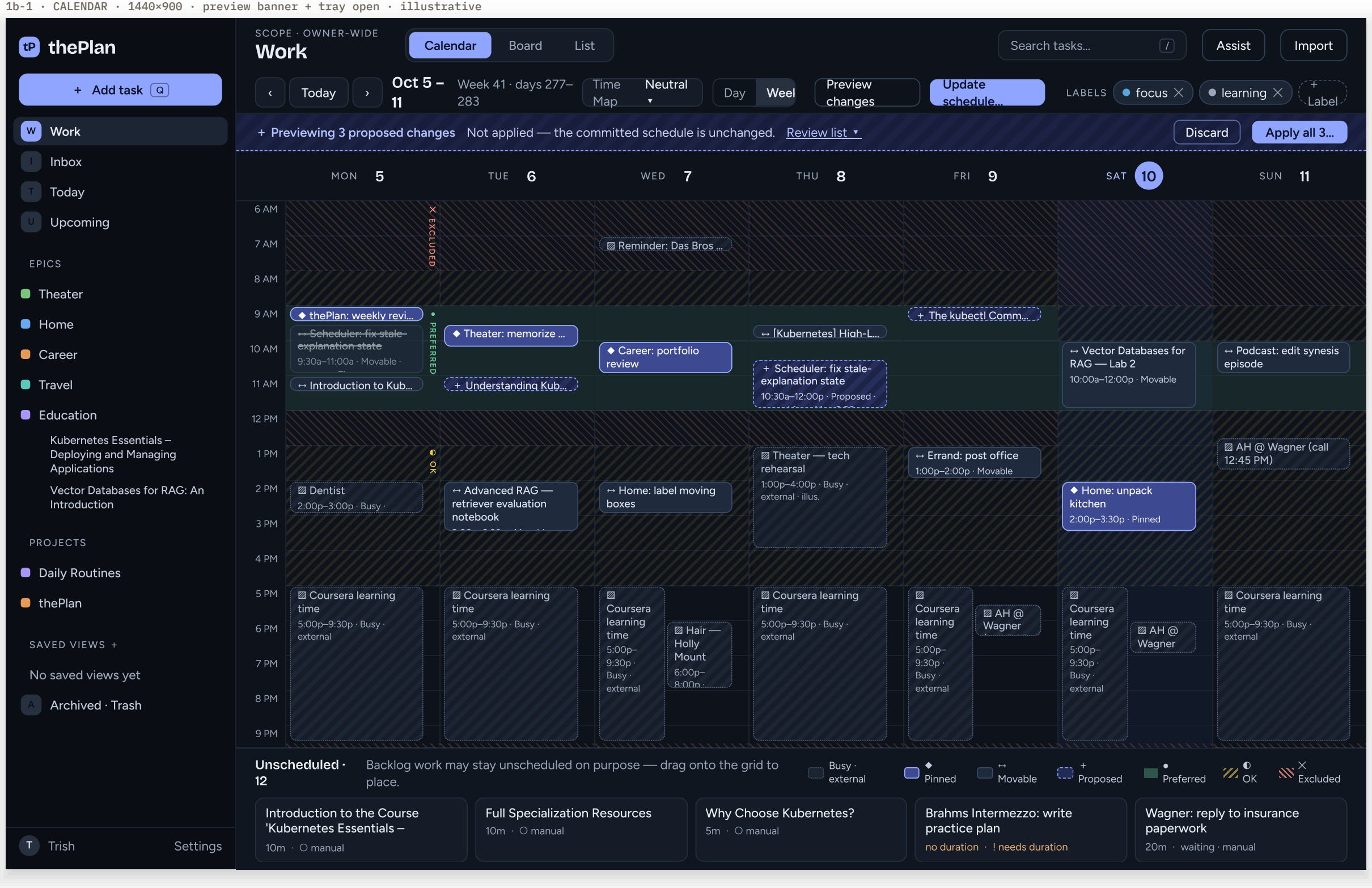
Interaction changes

- Scope switcher + view tabs replace the rail and its label list.
- Right dock: Unscheduled / Preview / Key; inspector replaces it when a task opens.
- Apply is all-or-nothing, labelled “Apply all 3...”.
- Completion circle is separate from card selection.

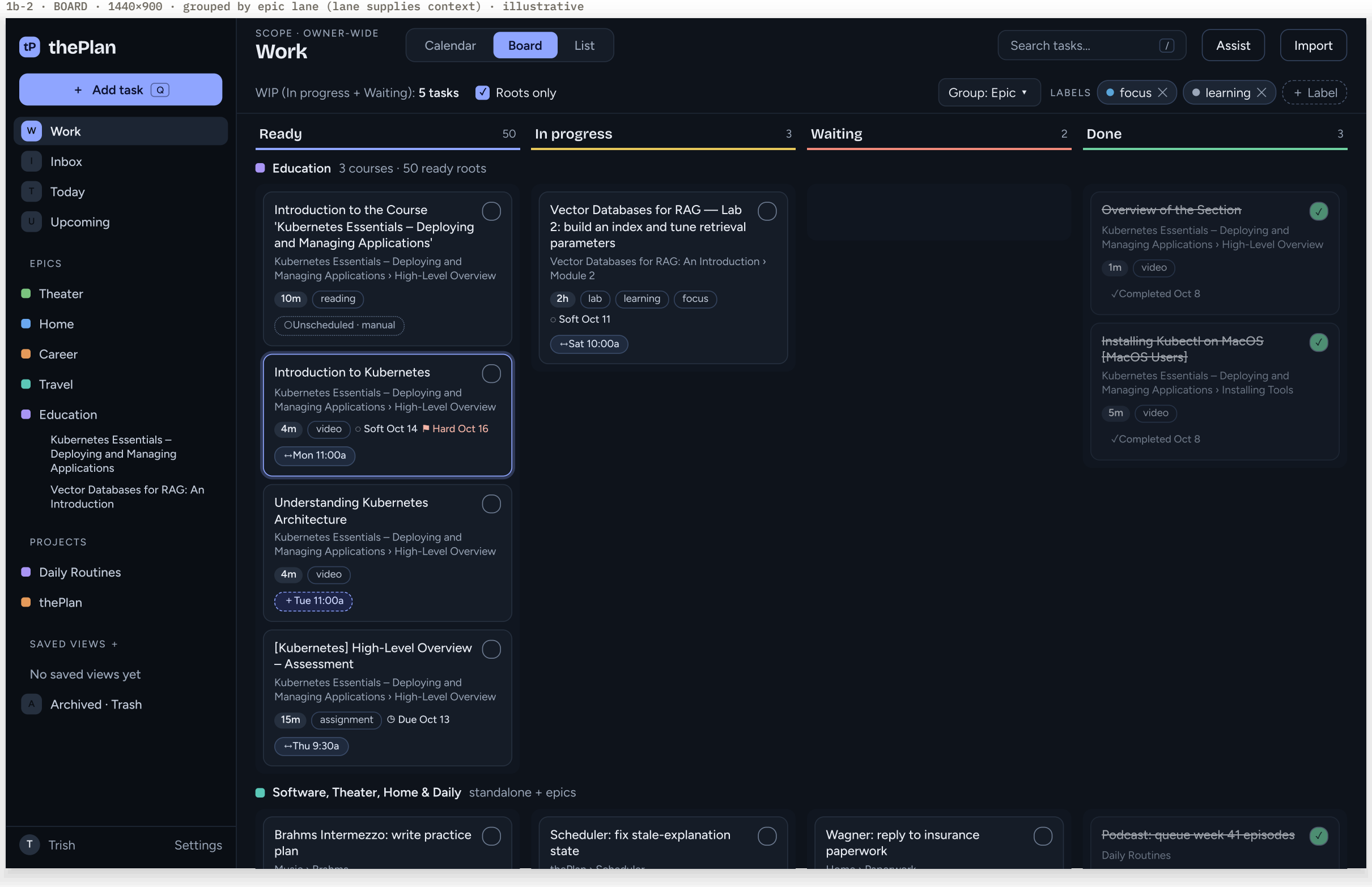
1b Studio

Roomier, cool-ink, persistent scope tree. Epic swimlanes on the board, a unscheduled tray under the calendar, a slide-over for detail.

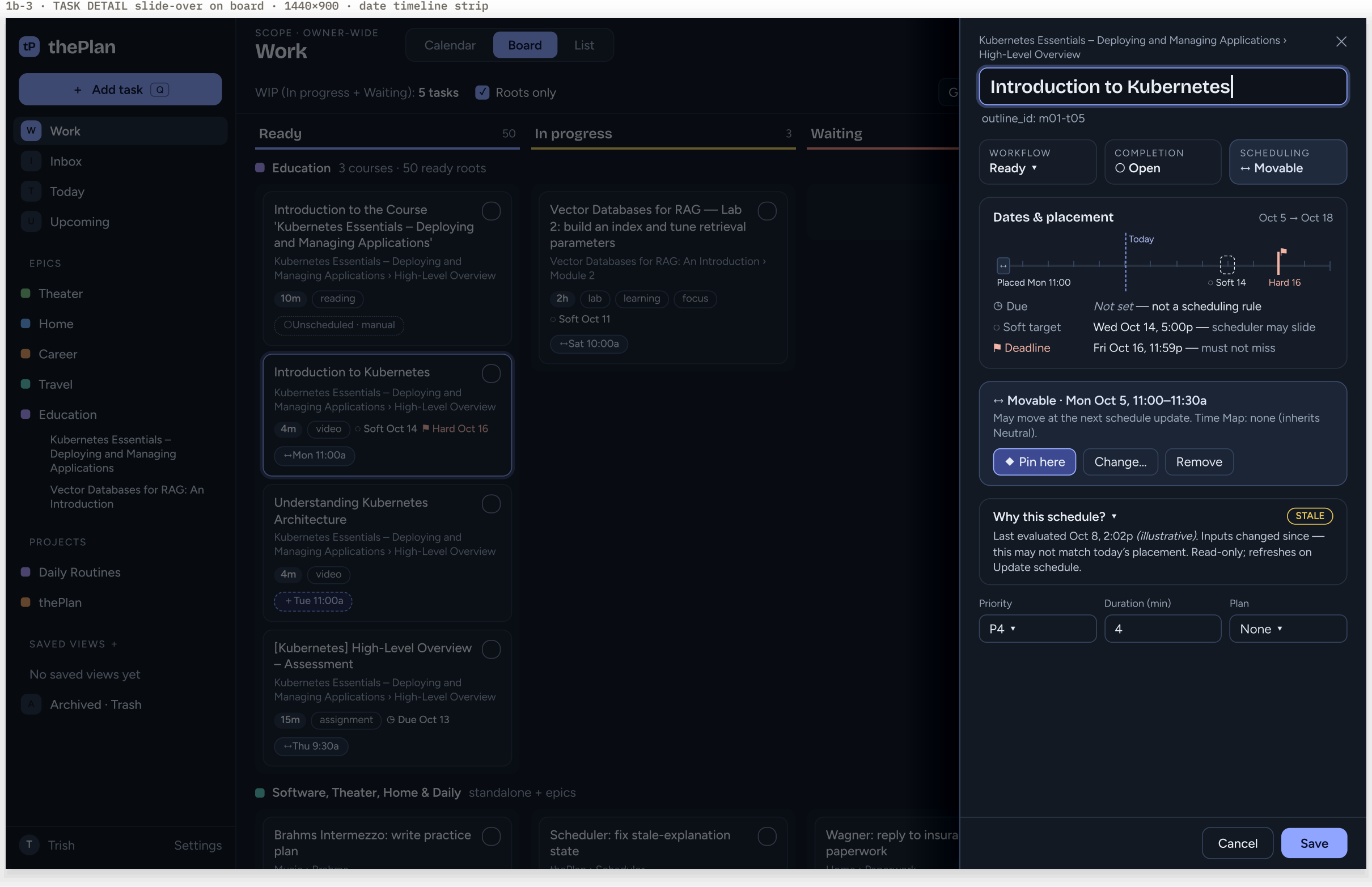
1b-1 · CALENDAR · 1440×900 · preview banner + tray open · illustrative



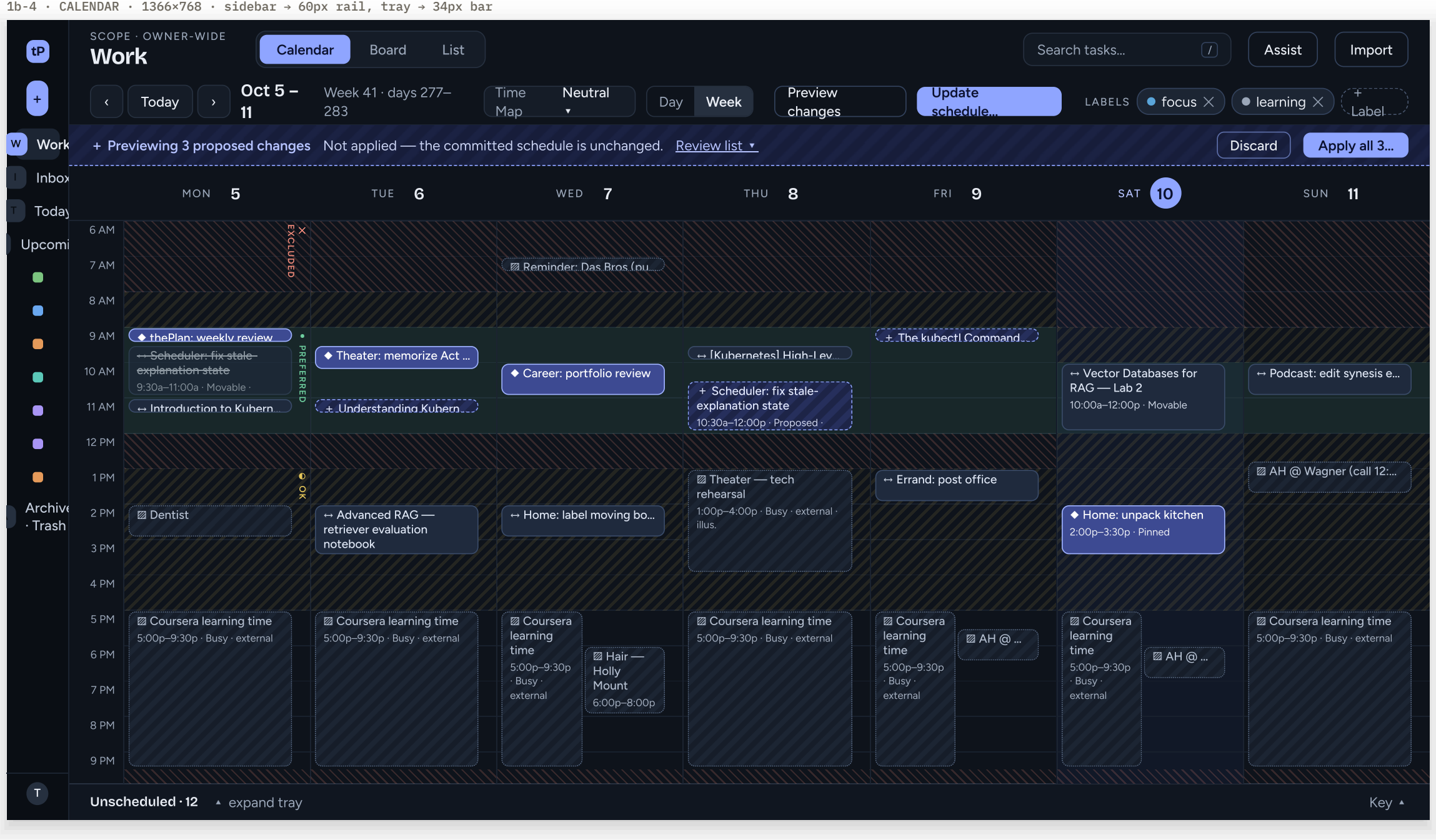
1b-2 · BOARD · 1440×900 · grouped by epic lane (lane supplies context) · illustrative



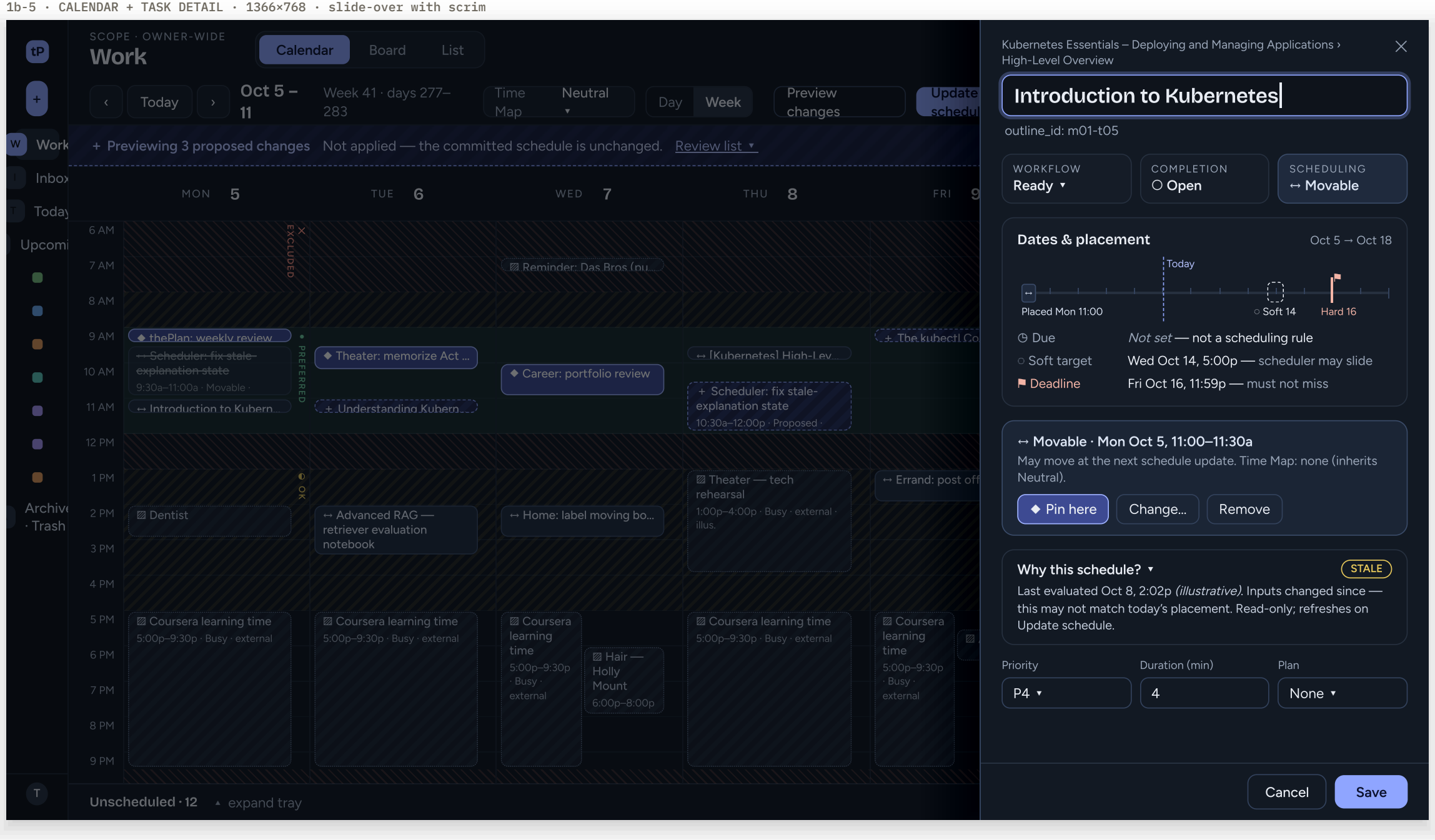
1b-3 · TASK DETAIL slide-over on board · 1440×900 · date timeline strip



1b-4 · CALENDAR · 1366×768 · sidebar → 60px rail, tray → 34px bar



1b-5 · CALENDAR + TASK DETAIL · 1366×768 · slide-over with scrim



Strongest benefits

- Persistent scope tree: epics, projects, saved views always one glance away.
- Epic lanes put context in the lane header; cards stay short.
- Date timeline in detail makes Due / Soft / Hard / placement legible at once.
- Preview banner is hard to miss.

Compromises

- Sidebar and bottom tray cost vertical and horizontal room (rail and bar at 1366 recover most).
- Grid hour height is ~37px at 900 tall vs 45px in Ledger.
- Slide-over hides the board while editing.
- Lanes need data on epic membership for every task.

Interaction changes

- Persistent scope tree; labels are chips in the toolbar.
- Bottom tray for unscheduled work; collapses to a bar.
- Slide-over detail with scrim; Esc closes.
- Board grouped by epic (selector).

Scope of each proposal

DIRECTION	TYPE	CHANGE
Both	Visual change	Dark palettes, typography, spacing; date glyph + word for Due/Soft/Hard; placement chips; Time Map patterns; external-busy hatch.
Both	Interaction change	Labels as filters, not navigation; separate selection and completion; dedicated Pin / Remove actions; Windows-first scoped shortcuts.
1a	Interaction change	Scope switcher replaces left tree; dock with Unscheduled / Preview / Key tabs; inspector docks beside content.
1a	New capability?	Preview list with per-change descriptions needs a change summary from the scheduler — verify. Selective apply / per-change undo are NOT assumed.
1b	Interaction change	Persistent scope tree; bottom tray; slide-over detail.
1b	New capability	Board grouped by epic lanes (needs epic on every task). Timeline strip is derived from existing dates — visual only.
2b	Interaction change	Saved-view builder: tri-state labels, searchable scope. The “≈ 37 tasks match” count is a new capability — verify.

Explanation states (both directions)

NEVER EVALUATED	No scheduling evaluation recorded. Read-only — run Update schedule to create one.
STALE	Last evaluated Oct 8, 2:02p (illustrative). Inputs changed since, so this may not match today’s placement.
CURRENT	Shown only when evaluation state is current and carries real reasons. Not mocked here — no reasons are invented.

Copy is shown only when real evaluation state exists. Nothing reassuring is invented for “never evaluated”.

Comparison and recommendation

CRITERION	1a LEDGER	1b STUDIO
Busy-week readability	Strong. Slim ribbons keep columns clear; lanes for overlaps. 45px/hour at 900.	Good. Tinted bands read like a heat map but eat contrast; 37px/hour at 900.
Navigation	Fast, compact; scope one click away.	Best for browsing epics/projects; costs 244px.
Kanban usefulness	Flat columns, full context on every card.	Epic lanes shine with many courses; needs lane data; taller.
Long titles	Wrap in cards, list and inspector.	Wrap; lane header reduces repeated path text.
Scheduling clarity	Dock holds preview, key and apply; calendar stays clean.	Banner + tray + key bar; clearest preview, busiest chrome.
Accessibility cues	Glyphs, dash/solid/hatch, words; focus ring amber.	Same cue set; softer borders need a contrast check.
Visual character	Technical, editorial ledger.	Friendly, app-like, more generic.
Implementation scope	Mostly restyle + layout.	Adds lanes, tray, slide-over, timeline.

RECOMMENDATION

1a Ledger, with one borrowed idea.

Trish treats calendar, board and list as equal working surfaces; Ledger gives all three the full width, keeps long titles wrapping, and asks for almost no new product capability. Support panels (preview, unscheduled, key) collapse to a strip so a daytime-heavy week stays readable at 1366 × 768.

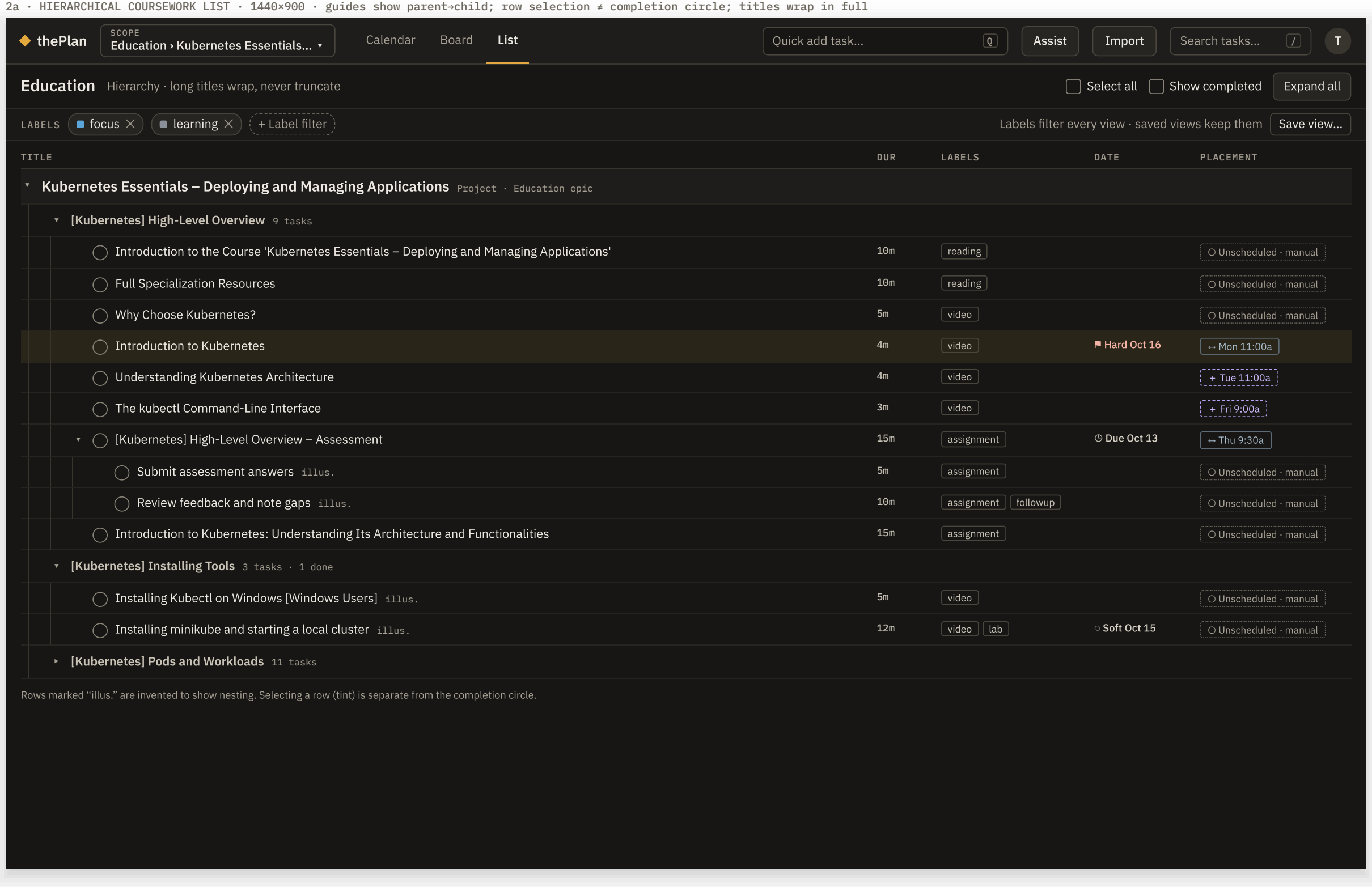
Compromise: epics, projects and saved views sit one click away in the scope switcher rather than always visible. Studio’s persistent tree is better for browsing; Ledger is better for working.

Worth borrowing from 1b (one refinement pass): the date timeline strip in task detail. It is visual only, derived from existing dates. Epic swimlanes would be a new capability — not recommended until confirmed.

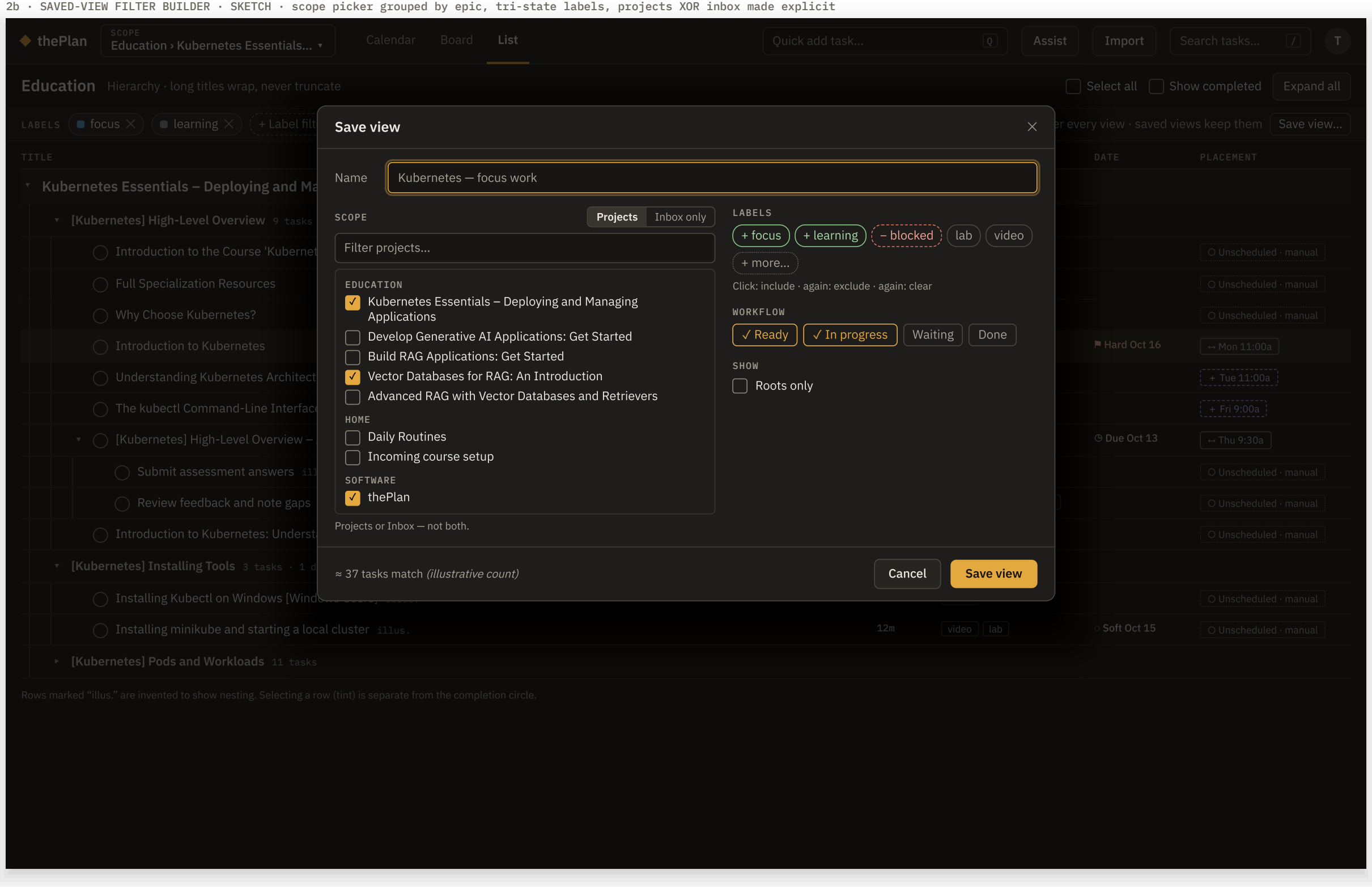
Recommended direction — list, dense form, specification

All in 1a Ledger. Subtasks marked “illus.” are invented to show nesting depth.

2a · HIERARCHICAL COURSEWORK LIST · 1440×900 · guides show parent→child; row selection ≠ completion circle; titles wrap in full



2b · SAVED-VIEW FILTER BUILDER · SKETCH · scope picker grouped by epic, tri-state labels, projects XOR inbox made explicit



Specification — type, space, surfaces

Type	IBM Plex Sans 13/1.35 body; 15–17 semibold titles; 11–11.5 metadata. IBM Plex Mono 10–10.5, caps, +0.08–0.1em for field labels and counts.
Spacing	4px base: 4 / 8 / 12 / 16. Toolbar rows 46 & 33; card padding 9×10; stack gap 8; list row 7 vertical.
Surfaces	App #171614 · panel #1e1d1b · card #232220 · raised #272522 · hairlines #2a2824 / #38352f / #4a463e.
Primary action	Amber #e3a93f fill, #1a1408 text, 600. One per view (Update schedule..., Save, Apply all). Secondary: #272522 fill, 1px #4a463e.
Selection	1.5px amber border + #252118 tint. Never implies completion.
Completion	Separate 15px circle; fills green with ✓; title strikes through, card dims to 65%.
Focus	1px amber border + 2px amber ring at 35% alpha, 1px offset. On every control, including tabs.
Text	Primary #ede9e2 · secondary #a8a195 (minimum on any surface).
Radius	4px blocks and chips; 6px controls and cards; 8px columns; 10px modals.

Semantic states — shape first, color second

▨ Busy · external	Hatch, never moved by the scheduler.
◆ Pinned	Solid amber outline; will not move.
↔ Movable	Slate. Movable ≠ permission for AI to act.
+ Proposed	Dashed violet; unapplied; separate from committed.
○ Unscheduled	Dotted; neutral — not flagged as needing attention.
! Needs duration	Ready but not schedulable until a duration exists.
Time Map: preferred	Solid ribbon.
Time Map: acceptable	Diagonal-stripe ribbon (see key in calendar dock).
Time Map: excluded	Crosshatch ribbon + faint wash; scoped to its own map only.
◷ Due ○ Soft ⚑ Hard	Three date meanings; unset shown as “Not set”.

Contrast — measured (WCAG relative luminance)

Computed from the hex pairs below. Static mockups do not establish keyboard or screen-reader accessibility.

FOREGROUND	BACKGROUND	RATIO
Text #ede9e2	App #171614	**14.9:1**
Secondary #a8a195	App #171614	**7.1:1**
Secondary #a8a195	Panel #1e1d1b	**6.6:1**
Secondary #a8a195	Card #232220	**6.2:1**
Amber #e3a93f	App #171614	**8.6:1**
Ink #1a1408	Amber #e3a93f	**8.7:1**
Pinned #f7ebd0	#3b3220	**10.7:1**
Movable #e1e9f0	#2b3238	**10.6:1**
Proposed #ebe3ff	#2b2540	**11.8:1**
Busy #c4bdb0	hatch #34312c	**6.9:1**
Hard date #f3b4a6	Card #232220	**9.0:1**
Stale #eab07a	Panel #1e1d1b	**8.8:1**

Known gap: chip and mono labels are 10–10.5px; raise to 11px in a refinement pass. Keyboard (Windows, proposal): *Q* quick add · */* search · *G* then *C / B / L* switch view · *Ctrl+K* scope · *Ctrl+Enter* complete. Single-letter keys are inert while a field has focus; Space, Enter and Delete never complete, move or unschedule work.

Unresolved questions

1. Does “Update schedule” apply immediately, or produce a preview first? Both screens assume preview → explicit apply of the whole set.
2. Is selective apply or per-change undo planned? These mocks assume neither, and say so on screen.
3. Is the calendar always showing exactly one Time Map (here “Neutral”)? Red exclusions are drawn only for that map.
4. Is the board’s Done column the same fact as task completion, or can a task be Done yet not complete (or the reverse)?
5. Is nesting deeper than course → section → task real? The list shows two illustrative sub-levels purely to test the pattern.

This is the end of the independent package. No further alternatives or refinement will start without Trish’s direction.